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Billy Taylor

Dr. Billy Taylor continues to be this country's most articulate and informed spokesman for American jazz. His unique perspective as a pianist, composer, educator and media figure have made him much in demand since his first gigs in New York in the early 1940's. He was born in North Carolina in 1921 and completed his Bachelor of Music degree from Virginia State College in 1942. His early career included work with some of the best soloists in jazz, including Dizzy Gillespie, Ben Webster, Cozy Cole and Machito, who inspired an avid interest in Latin music. He led his own trio during the 50's and 60's and later became the first black musical director on television, leading the band for the David Frost Show from 1969-72. His highly respected thesis on the history of jazz piano earned him a doctorate from the University of Massachusetts and he instituted the Jazz Alive radio series and the Jazzmobile in New York City. Dr. Taylor is a prolific composer, his best known work, "I Wish I Knew How it Feels to be Free" has been recorded numerous times, both instrumentally and as a vocal piece.

Dr. Taylor was interviewed by Dr. Michael Woods in New York City on July 27, 1995. Monk Rowe also participated briefly in the interview.

MW: We are filming a jazz archive series for Hamilton College, and we have with us here today one of the great men of jazz, Dr. Billy Taylor.

BT: Nice to see you.

MW: Let me just ask you some opening questions. You — literally you are a history of jazz. I mean you know so much about this music. I wanted to ask you, let's start chronologically and kind of move up. What attracted you to playing the piano and who were some of the other keyboard artists at the time that you started that kind of got you into the music?

BT: Well usually I answer that question by saying that I had an uncle who was my father's brother, everyone on my father's side played the piano. But this one uncle played jazz as opposed to European classical music, which everybody else played in my grandfather's church. So my Uncle Bob was really the catalyst for my interest. He gave me my first Fats Waller record, he gave me my first Art Tatum record, and he introduced me to a lot of the local pianists, many of whom were really terrific. And he knew everybody. And so he really got me turned on with this very exciting music that these people were playing.

MW: And how did you first start working professionally?

BT: My first job was when I was about 13 years old. I had been playing, you know, like little high school and junior high school gigs and one of the people that I had met through my uncle was working at the Howard Theater and he needed someone to replace him. For some reason or another everybody was busy, and so he knew my parents and he came over and he said, "look, I'll be personally responsible for your son. I'll make sure, I know

he's very young but I'm really in a desperate condition and I'd just like for him to cover for me for the early part of the evening. And I'll bring him home and everything will be all right, but, you know I'll take care of him. I'll make sure he's all right." And so that was my first job with older musicians, professional musicians.

MW: Now would you also say that that is an important aspect of the music? Where the younger musicians get their bearings and their diagnostic from the older musicians, they tell you, "yeah you're doing okay, just keep at it you know."?

BT: Well for me in the generation that I came up in the relationship between the older, more experienced musicians and the younger musicians was a good one. I mean they were very helpful, they were very — throughout my early days there was always some older, wiser musician that I could go to and say, "well how do you do this," or, "what about so-and-so" or "what happens if—" and get an answer. And I didn't represent a threat to them and you know, unlike the young man with a horn syndrome that people write about a lot, they had no, they were so secure in what they do, I was a kid, they say, "yeah come on kid — do whatever — you know, no problem." It wasn't teach you by shot.

MW: There wasn't this gunslinger mentality.

BT: No, not at all. Even when I was older, and I mean I was as rash and brash as any other guys just coming out of college, man, I mean I thought I was pretty mean, you know, so I'm ready to you know, shoot down anybody that came along. I mean I got spanked and put in my place, just like everybody else. "Oh yeah you think you can do that? Try this."

MW: And a little bit of that's healthy.

BT: Oh, yeah, oh yeah. Because it went hand in hand with encouragement. I mean it wasn't a put down, you'll never make it, or you don't have any talent, it was you know, "you can do that but you can't do this."

MW: Tell us some of the other people that you admired their playing at the time. You say you finished college.

BT: Yeah. I went to Virginia State College.

MW: Okay, tell me some of the other players that you admired when you finished undergraduate. Who were you listening to at that time? Who influenced you?

BT: Well I was lucky, I was lucky, I grew up in Washington, D.C. and in growing up in Washington, D.C., all the big bands came to the Howard Theater. My father, who was a dentist, had an office around the corner, literally around the corner from the theater. My grandfather's church was almost adjacent to the theater. So much of my family, the things that I was legitimately in place for, was close to this theater, where all of the great artists played. Where Duke Ellington, where Count Basie, where Jimmie Lunceford, all the great players came. And so I got literally to meet many people that I wouldn't have had access to had I not been in that proximity. I met Count Basie when I was in college. I

mean I was, I had the local, like at Virginia State we had a band that was the school band. It was an extracurricular activity. It wasn't something the school sanctioned, but it was a dance band and a bunch of kids, and we had a faculty advisor, and it was a very fine musician, a guy named Solomon Phillips, who taught me to arrange and do some other things. But the Count Basie's band was playing one nighters in Virginia. And they came through town. Well I mean we had all the Basie arrangements and we had, you know because in those days you could buy "One O'clock Jump" and "Jumpin' at the Woodside" and all those things for a dollar. I mean it was a stock arrangement, transcribed from the record, by some, whoever the company was. And it was a good transcription because they had the right, they had the Basie solo and it had everybody's solo in them. And so and we knew the arrangements. And so when the band came obviously everybody in the band wanted to go to hear these great musicians. And so we went, this was in Petersburg, Virginia. And so we went to the place where they were playing and we were standing around close to the band, nobody's dancing, everybody's listening to the — none of our group is dancing, we were listening to the music. And so a couple of the guys in my band met Jo Jones, who was a very accessible musician and said, "hey we've got a great piano player in our band, why don't you get Basie to let him sit in?" Well I was embarrassed, I mean, because, hey, sit in with this rhythm section? With Count Basie? Lots of luck, you know. I mean I was just happy to be there. Anyway, Jo said "oh yeah, let me check him out." And so he got Basie to let me sit in. So here I am with Freddie Green, Jo Jones and Walter Page. I mean a dream rhythm section you know? And that was my first meeting. I had seen them on stage and I had never been able to get backstage to meet them. It was my first person-to-person encounter with them. And from that point on, Jo was one of my mentors. So I mean he had a profound influence on my career.

MW: You know I want to ask you something about that. Because you know many of the musicians that we have interviewed have said the same thing. They said at some point early on in their careers, someone had faith in them and they said okay I'll give you a chance. I'll let you sit in. Or you meet that one person that you may be even intimidated by their status but they give you a chance. You know? And that's wonderful. I'd like to see more of that in the school systems.

BT: It's happening. It doesn't get the attention that it should because jazz doesn't get the attention that it should. But it happened with me prior to getting to Virginia State. I was in high school at Delmar High School in Washington, D.C. and Henry Grant was the band director there. And he was just a wonderful band director. I mean he had Frank Wess, the tenor player, we were in the same band. As a matter of fact Frank is the reason I don't play the tenor, because I figured if the tenor was supposed to sound like that I was

doing something wrong and I went back to the piano. Because he was a monster when he was just a teenager. I mean he was a wonderful player. And head and shoulders above most of us, you know. And so the — being in that context, I was lucky because not only did we have, did Frank and I have Henry Grant as a music teacher, we had James Reese Europe's sister Mary Reese Europe, also on that faculty. Because of racial prejudice in Washington, D.C., this was an all-black school. We had five instructors with doctorates on that faculty. And so we got like a prep school education and all of the artistic and cultural things that one would expect, and this was a public school, but we got all the cultural things that one would expect in a private school. As a matter of fact, Senator Eddie Brooke, a former Senator from Massachusetts, is from that school and any number of people that have achieved all kinds of things went to Delmar High School in Washington, D.C. It was a marvelous school. So we're very lucky.

MW: Let me ask you something about that. Okay, sometimes, and this is just my opinion, I feel that as far as the music goes, as far as jazz goes, that the racial separation actually did blacks some good. Because it made 'em play together.

BT: Not only did it make us play together, what happened is that the Duke Ellingtons, the Count Basies and the every strata of the music was available because they had nowhere else to go. We were all pressed into the black community. So everyone was accessible. I mean a man of Duke Ellington's stature, a man of Count Basie's stature, today would live, perhaps, in an area that I as a young musician couldn't afford. So therefore he would not be as accessible as if he lived upstairs in the apartment above me you know, as many of them did.

MW: And sometimes I think about that and it seems like as soon sometimes as you take the pressure off, then I find as an educator myself, that it's hard to get blacks involved in jazz, young blacks involved in jazz. There are not the numbers coming into it that there used to be.

BT: Well it's deeper than that, unfortunately. One of the reasons you don't have African-Americans in any number involved is that most of the traditionally black institutions ignore, in the same way that white institutions ignore jazz, for a variety of reasons. Most of the people who teach are trained in the conservatory situation, which does not consider jazz as the classical music it is. Therefore it's not studied, it is not given the proper attention, it is not related to the music of the twentieth century as it should be in an American institution. Now this goes black or white. It's particularly unfortunate in the black universities and schools because those kids are coming, too many of those kids are coming up not knowing their own history. And I think this is tragic. I've tried to do some things along those lines to help, but I've been frustrated. I mean I've tried to work with specific institutions and I just gave up because it was too time consuming and the interest

wasn't there, the help wasn't there. I've gotten much more — a project like this is in an institution that is not essentially a black university. But it's taking place because it's important and it's celebrating people who have done something of significance in the overall community, not just the black community. It seems very difficult to get black institutions to do this. Part of it is because of the tremendous brain drain that they suffered in the 60's after, when it became possible for many of the professors to go to places where they should have been in the first place — Harvard, Yale and other places. But it's had a detrimental effect on music.

MW: You know now I wanted to ask you, I'm going to go around this way and come back at that issue. You are one of the few musicians who has gone on to get the doctorate degree. Having been a professional and revered performer, you went back to get all the credentialing. Tell us about that. Tell us what made you do it, what motivated you and tell us a little about your research.

BT: Well I was recruited, to be honest with you. I had no intention of going back to school. I had studied privately and I was doing some private study here in New York. But I was so disenchanted with the educational system. I had been on committees, I had been on various things. I've always been interested in education. But I just felt that the educational system as it related to music was terrible. And it was not only ineffectual, it was doing a disservice to musicians in this country. I still believe that to a great extent, for other reasons. I think that we have all of these resources we have all of this history, we have all of this and we only look at a very small part of it. We only use a very small part of it for general education and for specific education. I think that's unfortunate. Anyway, I was recruited by Dr. Roland Williams from the Educational School at the University of Massachusetts. Roland Williams was, people don't know him, but he was a brilliant — he's still around but he's not in that position — he had a brilliant idea. He identified about ten to twenty people that he said, these are people who are teachers and don't know they're teachers. But they, if you look at what they do professionally, in everything they do there is some educational element. They are educating as they do their comedy or as they do their music or as they do their social work, or whatever it is. So he said maybe we can get all of these people up to the School of Education at U Mass and study them, and find some common denominator and put that into the hopper and make education a little more palatable. So he identified, among other people, Bill Cosby; Chris white, the bass player; Jimmy Owens, the trumpet player; Bill Barron, Kenny Barron's brother; Yusef Lateef; and myself, and many others. I don't remember all the people who were there, because we were there at different times. I was the musical director of the David Frost Show and so I wasn't interested in going back to school. I mean at that point I had a plateful man. I had a major talk show and I was the first black conductor on

national television, and so I was as busy as I needed to be. But Roland was a very pervasive and persuasive guy and he convinced me that they could work around my schedule and I could make this happen. Well it took five years, but I was able to do that primarily because once I got into the situation I found many things of interest. I found that it was possible to expand some of the other things that I was doing — Jazzmobile and some of the things that I was already involved in, in both educational and from a community point of view.

MW: Tell us about the Jazzmobile.

BT: The Jazzmobile came about in 1958, well, in the early 50's I had done a lot of lectures and I'd written some articles about jazz. I was very — Jo Jones had — when I first came to New York, immediately when I got here said, "Billy you've got to write a book." And he said, "you've got a college education and you know you're always spouting off about jazz this and jazz this, and you make a lot of sense so you ought to write it down." I says, "right." And I forgot all about that and I went on to try to learn how to play the piano. And ultimately in 1948, I did write a book — I wrote a little pamphlet — how to play bebop. And the reason I wrote it was because everyone had asked Dizzy and Bird to write it and they didn't, they didn't write anything at that point. So I felt that, hey, you're not giving away any secrets. Everybody is, as soon as you put it on records, everybody can take it off, I mean so why not write down what indeed is going on in terms of the harmonic, rhythmic and melodic expansions of this music. How Dizzy and Bird took what Basie and Ellington and their predecessors had done and how they expanded, what some of the differences were and what the similarities were. So I began to write articles about this and do things. In 1958 I was invited to the Music Educators' National Conference to give a speech and so was Stan Kenton that same year. And we both, not knowing — we knew each other but we didn't confer before we went to the conference — and we both said the same thing: you as music educators should be including jazz in your educational process. It is being done on an informal basis, but it needs to be codified, it needs to be put into the general aspects of music teaching. They pat us both on the head, thanks a lot, don't call us we'll call you. And I was furious. I said you knew I was a jazz musician, why did you waste my time coming out here all the way from New York to California. I mean I come out to California to visit my friends. I don't need to come out and be insulted you know. I was furious. And so was he. So we both came back and began to put in some kind of operation some of the things to say, you know, to thumb our nose at these people that we had very little respect for at that time. And what he did was to use his band as a workshop band. And what I did was a few years later — it took me a while to find a vehicle to do it — but a few years later I was a member of the Harlem Culture Council and they were looking for our first project. And I said okay,

what we should do is have jazz as a first project. And I couldn't find a way to make them do that. And a woman named Daphne Onstein went out to the World's Fair and said, you know, with all these millions of dollars of buildings and all these things that people spent money on, here are people following a mobile bandstand all through the fairgrounds. And they're listening to this live music. The city serviced our orchestra and they got Ray Nance in there, they got some jazz musicians in there and everything, but basically they were just playing nice music. And I said well why can't we do something like that? And so, "you opened your big mouth, you got the project." So I get the — we, Daphne and several other members of the Council and I went over to Ballantine Beer and got them to give us a parade float, and we put an electric piano on there, and went around the city. The idea was to update the New Orleans tradition. So we paraded — we took this float and went in a circle from say 137th Street between Lenox and Seventh Avenue, in a ten block radius. And we started there in a ten block radius and we came back playing as we went. And so we drew a second line. I mean kids were coming along and they were running along behind the parade. We had two police cars as buffers so they were safe, and it was like a little parade. We did this for a couple of years. Then the program began to grow. We started an educational part of it where we did workshops, where we did school concerts, and so forth. But it really was a way to bring the Count Basies, the Duke Ellingtons, the Dizzy Gillespies, the Lionel Hamptons, all of whom were very supportive, in coming out and having the people this close to them. Because even by the 60's, the music, there were very few big bands — being Basie, Ellington and Thad Jones and one or two others were really the basic big bands. I don't think Thad had actually started his when we started Jazzmobile. I think — what was the guy's name — Duke Pearson had a big band and there was always some kind of workshop band that had the fine musicians that were doing studio and stuff like that and wanted to play jazz. But Basie had a touring band, Ellington had a touring band and those were really the mainstays for us.

MW: A couple of other questions. This is marvelous. Do you feel that or can you give us specific examples, do you feel you were treated different or better after you finished your doctorate? And how? When did people begin to listen to —

BT: One of the funniest things to me, when I was working on my doctorate I was introduced to people as Dr. So-and-so, Dr. Such-and-such. As soon as I got mine it was Jim, Bill, I mean all of that stuff — I mean thanks a lot, yeah, okay. I didn't know any more than I did before. Yes I was treated differently. Because it was an unusual thing for a jazz musician to have an earned doctorate. And I rubbed people's noses in it. Because there was so much, when I was working on my doctorate there was so much that I found that was — well— sloppy research. And I found so many opinions in the music and so many things, in the research, and so many that were not identified as opinions. And I'll give

you one example. The thing that has frustrated me for many years, when I first came to New York, I had no idea of writing anything, I just wanted to know about the music. And I worked, my first job was on 52nd Street. So Jo Jones took me around and introduced me to many musicians. I was working with a friend of his, Sid Catlett. So I was working with it was Ben Webster's quartet. And so 52nd Street, in 1946, was a history of jazz. I mean you had everything from every kind of jazz that existed up until that period was represented on that one, actually in that one block, right down the street between Fifth and Sixth Avenue on 52nd Street just a few blocks over. These were all speakeasys, formerly. They were now legitimate night clubs. But there were ten on either side of that one block. There were four or five down in the block between Sixth and Seventh. But the main conglomeration of clubs was in that one block. So I, you know, naturally these are all super-stars to me. I mean these are the guys whose records I had heard and people who I had not heard of whose names I'd heard and never heard them play and all that, and it was a great opportunity to hear in person what Sidney Bechet sounded like or what Jimmy McPartland or some of the guys from Chicago who I'd read about and heard on radio but never seen you know. So I went to these clubs and I began to ask the musicians like Sidney Bechet and Wilbur De Paris what kind of music did they play when you were a kid. They said ragtime. So I said well — ragtime — did everybody play piano? I mean because I had read, by that time I had read the histories of jazz by Robert Goffin and by some of the — Hugh Panassie and people like that — who said that ragtime was piano music and it was pre-jazz. And these guys said something different. They said no. They said everybody played ragtime. They played ragtime in brass bands, they played ragtime on string ensembles and, you know, it wasn't just piano music. So I said well was it dance music? I asked a lot of questions about the music that was played when they were kids. And it turns out that it was the same thing, it was the predecessor to what they were playing. They were playing an extension of what they had heard when they were kids. And they had modified it to their own generation and everything. But basically it had remained pretty much the same from before 1900 right up until the 20's or early 30's you know? And these guys, when they were complaining about swing and some of the older guys were complaining about swing and saying well yeah, even playing swing as we do here, people don't recognize thematic things and they were talking about how they would improvise on the first theme and the second theme and whatever it was. And there were certain breaks and certain other traditions that went with that early music. And it was pervasive. It wasn't just on piano. So I come along later and I say well jazz is America's classical music, and the first identifiable style is ragtime. To date, very few people — I mean there have been a zillion books since my book came out. Most guys have gone back beyond my book and instead of doing their own research, because a lot of the same

statements that I said are in print. For instance, in Louis Armstrong's written work he says that. He talks about ragtime as early jazz. You know you guys didn't talk to Louis? I mean he was around for a long time. You guys didn't talk to Danny Barker? I mean there were a whole lot of old musicians that, some of whom were still with us, you know. And many people just read what somebody else wrote, copy that down, and then go on and put their own opinions in there.

MW: Let me ask you one other thing. I want to come in on that. I want to ask you to delineate for us some differences that you see between oral culture and literate culture. The reason why I say that is because we live in a society now where if the average person sees something in print they just believe it. Whether it's substantiated or not. And then the other thing —

BT: Beyond that is to hear it on television or radio.

MW: Yes. In any aspect of media. Now if they hear it they believe it to be so. And of course the media can be slanted and it can be wrong and it can be extremely slanted. I'll give you an example then I'll let you go on it. For instance, you know I've seen in the last five years the way that people have kind of denigrated African-Americans in the media. I'll give you an example. Ted Koppel says something — "how witty, how insightful." Bryant Gumble says the same thing — "arrogant." Look at the usage of terms. The man may have said the same thing. But it's the way that it's depicted and brought to the public. But I want you to tell us for instance, what you feel about oral culture. How is jazz a manifestation of oral culture? And how can we continue that and bolster that?

BT: Jazz coming from an African-American point of view, having been created by Africans and their subsequent generations, has continued the same tradition, the griot, and since Africans and African-American slaves were, it was against the law to teach them to read and write in many states, they had to continue the oral tradition. It is my opinion that jazz would not exist if the Virginia and North Carolina and South Carolina and the southeastern states, forbidden the use of the drum because they felt it was a rallying point and so forth. If they had not done that, it's my opinion that the music created in this country would sound more like West Indian music or like Cuban music or like some of the other music created by people who came from the same circumstances and same tribes that the Africans who were brought here but were taken to Cuba, taken to Haiti, taken to places in South America like Brazil and so forth. The music — because they were allowed to keep the drums — has a more direct relationship to the African — its African beginnings. Right now what you've got is you can't use the drum so therefore you internalize this rhythm, you do something else with it. You clap your hands, you shuffle your feet, you do other things to get the rhythmic context into the melody and the harmonies that you use and the vocal sounds and orchestral sounds you use. That is

exciting but I don't read, I don't see that in print. I do see this, I do hear this, in the oral traditions that have come down. So when you talk and you read or hear what Jo Jones said or what Ellington said or when you hear direct quotes from Count Basie or from other people, you see a lot of information, you hear a lot of information that does not appear in the written versions of what the music is about. When you go to the Smithsonian and you hear what the musicians said in answer to questions, when you listen to the Jelly Roll Morton interviews that were years ago, when you hear Milt Hinton interviews, when you hear various people who were there and who are talking history in the first person, it's quite different from anything I read.

MW: You know another thing I want to ask you about, because you said you had relatives that were ministers in a church. I wanted to ask you if you have your own church background and how that has become a part of your expression in jazz. Because you know the black church is like the pillar of the black community. A lot of things spiral out from that. And then I want to ask you about the spiritual nature of the music. Because to me the music has always been about more than just my ability to play this complex scale or this complex chord.

BT: Well in my case, my grandfather, as I said was a Baptist minister. He was one of the founders of the [inaudible] Baptist Church. We spent a lot of time in church. My father was the choir director. His sister and brothers played the organ. There were a lot of choir rehearsals in my house. So I grew up hearing the spirituals, hearing the black rendition of the traditional church music of the Baptists. And I recall many Sundays when after the eleven o'clock service, we went back around three o'clock on a Sunday to hear a new preacher. And so this preacher was someone who had been invited to preach to this church and you know, man I had a lot of things I would rather do on a Sunday afternoon, but my father, the family went to church. So on those occasions, the choir sometimes wasn't there. And I never understood why or when, because sometimes it was but sometimes it wasn't. And they would sing things that I never heard on other occasions. These were either older pieces of music that seemed to start with some of the older beings some of the older members of the congregation would start to sing these things. And I realized later that they were some of the older spirituals that were less formal than the ones that had been written down and had been taught to us. But they remembered them. And for whatever reason felt that it was more appropriate to sing those at that particular occasion. And it seemed to have something to do with gathering the spirit and really just helping this guest minister feel the spirit. I mean like they'd say the traditional stuff is not working, let's go back into tradition to help this brother, you know? And I found it interesting just as a musician. Because first of all it was music that was different from what we normally did. And I couldn't figure what the difference was. I mean I know now

that the form was different. It was really like they were singing — the closest thing I can relate it to is if you listen to the Georgia Sea Islands records — those kinds of things — that's the kind of music basically that we heard in this context. And I don't know it just moved me in a different way. It didn't, that was the part, I didn't usually care for whatever the brother was preaching, but the music was, something was going on. And I couldn't figure it out. It had to do with touching you, with music touching you. I mean I have felt the same way later with European music and with Indian music and with other kinds of music. And I didn't have to know what that was. It was just that that piece of music in that particular context reached out and I said, oh man, wow, it just did something for me. And so this was that kind of association. For me it is an important part of everything I do. I mean the most used piece of music I have ever written is a piece called "I Wish I Knew How it Would Feel to be Free." And that is in hymnals. I wrote it for my daughter because I was just trying to show her about her traditions. She was growing up in the 50s and 60s and really coming up with Motown and a lot of other things. And I'm saying, "Well that's all right, but you have a tradition that goes beyond what I play and Motown and all of that. And you should know about that." And she wasn't getting that. We're Catholic. And so she wasn't getting that in church as I did. And so I figured as a father I should do that. And she was saying, "right, sure, thanks Dad." Now she is grown and much more aware, having gone through experiences of her own and gone back and looked and listened to things out of her own tradition, so she's much more aware than she was, you know, than I tried to make her. She did that on her own. But I wrote this trying to show her, I said you know this is something I can make up. It's so important in your tradition. So I wrote the piece in about 15 minutes. I played it and I said that's good and I liked it so I wrote it down. And it's only about a 16-bar piece. But since then, so many other artists have done it. Nina Simone had the classic record on it in terms of like most of the singers who sang it sang the version based, their versions are based on her version. And her version is based on my instrumental version, which I did at the piano. But spiritual, I've written in recent years, something based on the concept that Ellington called "Sacred Music." Where you use your best shot as far as what you do as a composer. And you try to say, using all the information at hand, something that has a religious context. And this was based on the Psalms that say "Make a Joyful Noise To the Lord." As a matter of fact that's the title of the piece. It's a seven movement work, and it's "Make a Joyful Noise."

MW: The reason why I asked that is this. Is — you said the piece was called "I Wish I Knew How it Would Feel to be Free," but the thing I'm seeing in that is do you find in a general sense that for African Americans that this music the Gospel, the church music, the jazz,

411 even the rhythm and blues, afforded some degree of sonic autonomy even if there wasn't
412 that degree of autonomy in the workplace?
413 BT: Well this piece, "I Wish I Knew How it Would Feel to be Free" refers to someone who
414 wants to fly like a bird, someone who feels that, you know, give me an opportunity to do
415 what I do best, I mean I wish I were free to do the things, to break the bars that are
416 holding me, to do the things that I know I can do. And so that's the nature of the piece.
417 It's been used by the women's movement and it's been used by a whole lot of other folks
418 that feel the same way. But one of the I guess most lasting contributions we have made
419 has been musical. What we do, which is inherent in jazz and gospel and in all of the, in
420 rap, in all of the types of expression that come out of the black experience, there is that
421 degree of, "this is what I have to say." Now we may not all agree on what I have to say
422 but this is, I'm expressing it at this point you know? We may do it altogether at some
423 point. But right now, I've got the floor. And this happens with Aretha, it happens with
424 Erroll Garner, it happened with Duke Ellington, it happened with Count Basie. I
425 remember when I —
426 MW: Lord have mercy it happens with Patti Labelle.
427 BT: Oh tell me about it.
428 MW: She takes over.
429 BT: She really does. She sure does. And you know you can, I remember being, I was house
430 pianist at Birdland for two years. And the Basie band played there frequently. And
431 usually when the band played, Birdland was a small club, and the band took up the entire
432 stage and part of the band was really down on the floor almost. And Basie was sitting at
433 the piano and the piano was on the floor. And so the exciting thing was to hear Joe
434 Williams get up and sing to — it wasn't a predominantly white audience in those days.
435 Because it was the, at Birdland, it was a very hip contingent of people who came
436 downtown consistently. So you had 60/40 one night — white/black; and 60/40 the next
437 night — black/white. So it really was a very interesting balance in that particular club.
438 And so it was interesting to me regardless of which way the balance was in terms of the
439 ethnic background, Joe would reach out and grab those folks with the classic things that
440 he was doing with Basie in those days, and it didn't make any difference, it was just a
441 straight arrow to that audience you know. And it was really a very hip audience. I mean
442 this is the audience that was so hip that normally the piano was on the stage and I would
443 be seated here and I could hear, they didn't realize it, they didn't realize it, but the people
444 sitting right behind me I could hear their conversations. Sometimes I didn't want to. But I
445 mean I could, you know, it was audible. And I'd be sitting there and the guy would be
446 sitting behind me talking to his buddy. And he says "man, you know Bird doesn't sound
447 as good tonight as he sounded night before last." "Night before last he was hip —" And

he'd name the players and these people were, these were not musicians. But these were people who had heard the music, had valid opinions as far as what — as the quality of the music that they were listening to was. I miss that. I miss that. Because in those days they were getting it from Symphony Sid on the radio, on Nashville radio he was doing a coast to coast broadcast from midnight to six o'clock in the morning every night in the week. There was much more music. There was music, jazz on television, there was jazz all over. This is one — since we don't have this this is one of the reasons that people don't relate to the music in the way that you and I perhaps would like to see them.

MW: I wanted to ask you one closing question. I just want to make a comment on that and that is I feel that many times the audiences, they don't follow the music as closely. They're not as into it. They don't seem to be, there isn't the quality of listener. Therefore the audiences don't seem to put the same type of demand on the performers. They don't draw it up out of the performers they way they used to. But I wanted to ask you one closing question here. If you could see anything that you wanted happen in jazz education. If the jazz education world came to you on its knees and said, "Billy, you're the guru, lead us." And you could carte blanche write what you wanted to have happen. Give us a, I don't know we don't have two weeks, but give us a little scenario if you could have what you wanted in the jazz education world. Just paint us a little picture.

BT: Actually I wrote this in a book which was edited by Dave Baker. I was asked to make some suggestions as to where jazz could go. In education, where I'd like to see jazz go, I would like for people to recognize the intrinsic value of the music and to use it. Because it is like an ostrich to have your head in the sand and not realize that jazz has been the most pervasive music of this century. I mean the kinds of things that have come, that have been most popular, much of this music and the concepts that created the music, have come out of jazz. To take these things and to put them into their proper perspective, tells us who we are and what we're about. So it's beyond just music. It's beyond culture. What's going on as we speak with Congress getting rid of the NEA and trying to find ways to de-fund the arts makes it more mandatory to belabor a point, makes it really mandatory to put, to enhance, the 35,000 jazz ensembles that are in place already in schools around this country, to improve the instruction, to improve the visiting artist programs, to bring in to personal contact not just students who are interested in music, but students who are just ordinary people who when exposed to good music of any style will respond. You need to, jazz needs to be on television. It needs to be on video. It needs to, those of us who have the ability to project it, should do more. I do the only program on national television on Sunday morning that gives a look at the artists, an inside look, at the artists who are important in jazz. And this is six, from six to ten minutes of a 90 minute show. You know this is one time, maybe two or three times a month that this

happens. Of course that's not enough. We've got thousands of people that deserve this kind of attention. You've got people who are doing other kinds of things that people should see and should hear. So we need to use video and we need to use radio still, because radio is still a valid place for people to get information. It is being disseminated in many ways, the music is being disseminated in many ways by people who love it but don't know a lot about it. And so they're putting music out there sometimes in a strange context. The music business needs to be educated better to realize that real jazz sells, has always sold. To take an example of Miles Davis, Miles Davis sold as many records as any rock act that you can think of. But he sold that many records over a period of years. He didn't sell them all the first week. I mean what happens in many of the very popular groups, they sell a lot of records over a very short time. Then they're dead. Nobody buys a record ever again. With jazz, it goes on and on and on. And the problem has been distribution. We don't get it into the hands of our students. We don't get the music into the ears of the people who are the mayors of the town or who are, I've run into too many people who say well hey, I've got a doctor's degree, I never had any art, I mean who needs aesthetics? I mean you get that after you get rich or something. These are people who honestly believe that visual arts and music and the things that as far back as one can determine in Africa and certainly through the Greeks and the Romans and in other civilizations, have proven that this is what you remember a culture for. You don't remember, I don't remember who the politicians were or who the generals were in those days. But I do see some of the artifacts that have been left behind and experience some of the music in more recent, from more recent excavations of those traditions.

MW: Well these are fabulous insights — yes?

MR: We have about another ten minutes before the driver comes — do you have any more stories about what it was like to be on the road perhaps?

BT: Well let me talk about the Basie thing.

MW: Okay, wonderful, marvelous.

BT: Count Basie was one of the most genuinely modest people that I think I've ever met. I tried as a radio announcer, on television shows, tried to interview him for many years and we were good friends. He would always talk to me, but he would always talk about the guys in the band. And I once asked him how he'd like to be remembered and he said, "as a guy in the band." But I did, I was fortunate in going to Kansas City. I flew in from Chicago where I was working and did a special interview for a documentary that was being done by Public Television. I did 55 minutes on Count Basie, where Count Basie talked about Count Basie. It was the best interview I have ever managed, on him. I'm so proud of that. Because Nebraska Television, it was done for them. If you can ever get ahold of it, you get Basie talking — in the interview itself — you get Basie talking about

things that, how he sat at the feet of Fats Waller, and how he learned to play the organ, and he said, "I put my hands where his feet were so I would know where to go." And you get him talking. I asked Basie about, because his music was so blues oriented. I said well, "how did you learn to play the blues in Red Bank?" And he said, "well I didn't really learn to play the blues until I came to Kansas City." I said well, "you're kidding. You came out here with a blues act." And he said, "Oh, no, no, no, no." He said no, because he had been stranded in Kansas City, having come there with a vaudeville act. And he said "no everything was billed as blues in those days. They were singing other, what was kind of a pop music for those days" and so forth. And he said, "but when I got here, I really heard the blues." And it really infected everything that he did. And it was the kinds of bands that he put together, the kinds of singers that enhanced that band, like Joe Williams, like Jimmy Rushing and Helen Humes and they each had a particular perspective that he was interested in. When Billie Holiday sang with the band it was a kind of a special relationship. And he had, I don't know whether she sang with the band on a regular basis. I saw her with the band, as a matter of fact the first time I ever saw her was at the Howard Theater with the Count Basie band. And I was really, this was the classic Basie band. I really didn't want to hear Lady Day, I must confess, because I wanted to hear Herschel Evans and Lester Young hook up. I mean I'd been hearing about these two guys and I heard a little bit on "One O'clock Jump" and all that, and I wanted to hear them tangle you know. And they didn't do that on that particular show. But there were, there is so much of the tradition, the individuality when you look at the Basie band and the Ellington band, and you look first of all at what the band sounds like. You listen to what the band sounds like. Then you look at the fact at how can that band sound so together with individual sounds that are so different? I mean when you think about the Basie reed section — the traditional reed section — I mean you've got Lester Young and Herschel Evans, how can they sound good? I mean it's totally different sounds that you're blending together. That's one of the beauties of jazz. The Ellington band with the Hodges and Ben Webster and Otto Hardwick, and how do you make those things come together? There is a camaraderie. There is a mutual respect musically that musicians earn, therefore when they work together, something happens that does not happen when they're playing singly. And so you hear this mass of sound from the Basie band, and someone will get up and you will say well gee that works, and it will be Sweets Edison or somebody. And someone will get up at another point and you say well that sounds like Sweets but it's different — that's Joe Newman. And I mean and so you come up with, then you'll have the two Franks battling or you'll have all of these kinds of sounds. When Lockjaw Davis went with the band, this guy was such an individual, I said he can't possibly sound good in that context. Because I had heard him at Minton's and playing all

his own stuff, and he was so individual. I said he's going to stick out like a sore thumb. But he didn't. I mean you know? Clark Terry in the band and you hear Clark's sound through everybody, but in that band, it just was a part of the Basie sound. And I think this is something that jazz musicians do that needs to be studied. I think that if we could find out what that is, what makes that possible, we'd be, we'd go a long way to understanding what it is that makes music have the kind of impact that it has on the psyche of people who are not musicians. Why Joe Williams instead of a zillion other male singers? You know? I mean he had something that reached out and grabbed people. I mean this guy standing in — no show biz — just standing there singing you know? Singing the blues. And singing — always wanting to be a ballad singer and singing gorgeous ballads, but in that context, primarily singing three or four blues things and tearing it up every time. Because it reached out and grabbed people. Jazz is an individual expression which I believe takes all of the — takes one particular element that we hold dear in our society, and that is the individual, the right of the individual to express himself. And when you look at jazz, that's really what it's about. Every great jazz artist makes a personal statement and you would not mistake any of the major artists for any other artist. Even though Dizzy Gillespie was highly influenced by Roy Eldridge, who was highly influenced by Louis Armstrong, you know. Miles Davis, highly influenced by Dizzy Gillespie but had to go somewhere else. He didn't have that kind of facility you know? Lee Morgan was tremendously influenced by Clifford Brown. Freddie Hubbard, tremendously influenced by Clifford Brown. All have to do something else, you know?

MW: I think that's what makes it so beautiful is the fact that it allows for individual expression, it allows for exploration, and you eventually have to arrive at that exploration in order to find yourself.

BT: I liken it to the way we learned to talk. And trying to explain this to young students, you know when I learned to talk I learned from my family, I learned from my mother and father, the way they pronounced certain words, or older cousins and uncles and aunts and so forth. But even as I got to be, before I got to be a teenager, I mean I was saying things that were my own voice. I didn't sound like my father or like my brother or anyone else. I mean this is the way I expressed that. You know, right or wrong, that was the way I felt about it. And that is what I think one of the main contributions of the music is.

MW: Well thank you Dr. Taylor. It's been marvelous talking to you. Wonderful insights. And I'm sure that Hamilton College will be delighted to have this interview. Thank you.